ISO CHECKLIST / PRACTICAL AUDIT FIELD GUIDE

An Evidence-Led Internal Audit

A Practical Starter Guide

A small audit is useful when another person can retrace how you reached a conclusion. Start with a clear criterion, choose a defensible sample, and record both what the evidence supports and what remains uncertain.

Start with a decision you can support

Use this guide to plan one process audit and carry a finding through to an evidence-based closure decision. It provides a workflow, an example evidence register and a worked follow-up. Adapt it to your own approved audit method, risks and responsibilities.

Criterion -> sample -> evidence -> finding -> action -> effectiveness check

Worked case: production-instruction releases

All organisations, procedures, record IDs, quantities and results in the worked case are invented for illustration. At the fictional Alder Workshop, an internal procedure requires approval of each revised production instruction before release to the shop floor. The audit question is: did the release process apply that rule to recent changes?

Before you start

Obtain current approved criteria and an agreed scope. Choose a competent auditor who can evaluate the process objectively. Arrange secure access to evidence and agree how confidential records will be referenced.

The procedure used in this case is an invented local rule, not an ISO requirement. This original educational guide does not reproduce a standard or replace the applicable licensed standard. It is not official ISO guidance, an assurance opinion or a certification guarantee.

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01 / PLAN, TEST, FOLLOW THROUGH

An eight-step workflow

Keep the evidence trail intact at every handover.

01 Define the decision

Write the process, boundary, period and audit objective in one sentence. Decide who will use the result. Record exclusions so the report cannot be mistaken for a review of the whole organisation.

02 Set the criteria

List the approved requirements you will test: for example, a controlled procedure, a contractual obligation or the applicable standard. Record the version and approval status. Resolve conflicting criteria before interviewing people.

03 Choose the sample

Identify the population and explain the selection. Include a mix relevant to the risks, such as recent changes, unusual cases or past problems. A targeted sample can reveal weaknesses; it does not establish a population-wide failure rate.

04 Prepare the evidence route

Arrange access, an auditor with suitable competence and independence, and a process owner. Set rules for confidentiality. Prepare questions that follow work from input to output, with a place to record evidence IDs.

05 Follow the work

Ask someone to demonstrate a real completed case. Compare records, observation and explanation. Check dates, versions and approval trails. An interview can explain a record, but an unsupported statement cannot establish that a step occurred.

06 Test and describe the gap

For each conclusion, connect the criterion to the evidence and the specific shortfall. Confirm factual accuracy with the process owner. Distinguish a proven mismatch from missing access or an unanswered question; record limitations openly.

07 Agree the response

Assign an accountable action owner and a due date. Separate correction of the immediate issue from action on its cause. Agree what later evidence would demonstrate effectiveness before accepting the action plan.

08 Verify and report

Check that the promised change happened, then test whether it worked over a suitable period. Record the sample, result, reviewer and closure rationale. If evidence is insufficient, keep the finding open and define the next check.

02 / BUILD A TRACEABLE RECORD

An evidence register

Give each evidence item a stable ID. Record enough context to retrieve and assess it without putting sensitive source material into an unrestricted report. Keep the underlying record in an approved repository with appropriate access and retention controls.

ID	Source and context	What was checked	Interpretation and limit
E-01	Change register, revision 7; export reviewed on audit day.	Population: 18 production-instruction releases in the defined four-week period.	Defines the sample frame; does not prove approvals happened.
E-02	Six selected release packs; IDs R-101, R-104, R-108, R-111, R-115, R-118.	Two packs lack a recorded approval before issue; four show approval timestamps.	A targeted sample of 6/18. No claim about the remaining 12 releases.
E-03	Controlled local procedure WI-04, revision 3.	Requires approval before a revised instruction is issued.	Approved local criterion for this illustrative case.
E-04	Demonstration of the release queue and owner interview.	The release screen can accept a blank approval field.	Corroborates a possible process weakness; cause still needs investigation.

In a working register, add the reviewer, review date, source location, access owner and retention rule. The IDs above belong only to the fictional example.

A finding that can be checked

Against WI-04 revision 3, approval before issue was not demonstrated for releases R-104 and R-115 in the six release packs reviewed (E-02). The release register identifies 18 releases in the period (E-01); the conclusion is limited to the tested sample. No conclusion is made about the other releases.

Handle uncertainty explicitly

If approvals might exist elsewhere, record that uncertainty and make a bounded follow-up request. If they are then produced, update the finding. Do not turn an access problem into a proven failure, or assume that an absent record proves an activity never happened.

03 / MAKE CLOSURE AN EVIDENCE DECISION

A change is not yet a result

Record	Purpose	Illustrative example
Finding	The observed mismatch between a criterion and supported evidence.	Two sampled release packs lack demonstrated approval before issue.
Correction	The immediate response to the affected items and consequences.	Review the two instructions, control their use and check whether affected work needs attention.
Corrective action	The change chosen to address an investigated cause and prevent recurrence.	If investigation confirms the release gate is the cause, require verified approval before release and test exception handling.
Effectiveness	Evidence that the change achieved its intended result over an agreed period.	Recheck later releases and exceptions; compare outcomes with the agreed acceptance criteria.

Follow-up that can change the decision

Illustrative plan: the process owner investigates why the approval gate was bypassed and checks for similar releases. A separate reviewer validates the new gate before use. After four weeks, the reviewer examines all 12 later releases and every exception in that period. The agreed criteria are that every release has a valid approval timestamp before issue and each exception follows the approved route.

Illustrative outcome: 11 releases meet the criteria; one exception lacks approval. The finding stays open. The reviewer records the failed criterion and asks for a revised response plus a new review period. A completed training log or a screenshot of a changed form alone would not establish effectiveness.

Hand over a usable audit record

Your final record should contain: scope and criteria; auditor and review dates; population and sample rationale; evidence IDs; clear findings and limits; action owners and dates; and the effectiveness result with an explicit closure decision. Keep the finding, action and follow-up records linked so responsibility does not disappear between them.

Related publisher resources

Internal audit resources for related checklist and reporting formats.

ISO 27001 resources for readers planning an information security management system audit.

ISO Checklist resource library for editable Word and Excel management-system documents.

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